

Infrastructure Is Influence: Takeaways and Starter Kit

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Thank you for downloading this document and for attending my talk at WUC Graz 2026. This document has two parts: the takeaways from the talk, and the Organizational Memory Starter Kit to help you put infrastructure and influence into practice.

Part 1: Talk takeaways

For UX researchers, influence doesn't come from a seat at the table. It comes from infrastructure: a home for all research, wherever it comes from, and a set of rules that help an organization remember what it learns.

The big idea

Research is being democratized. More people are doing it, and that's a good thing: it means organizations are learning more about the people they serve, the processes they rely on, and the problems they need to solve.

But most of that research happens without a system for capturing, connecting, and sharing what's learned. Instead, much of it ends up in folders, on laptops, or in someone's head, and the organization doesn't know or doesn't remember what it's learned or what to do next. In organizations like this, research is at risk of being repeated, ineffective, and lacking the power that cumulative knowledge can have on solving problems long-term.

ResearchOps gives researchers the opportunity to change that by creating a system with a set of rules that everyone who does research can follow. It encourages project leaders to ask, "What do we already know?" before starting something new. And it builds on itself, as what's learned from each project is added back into the system. This is research that can truly influence decisions without a researcher needing a seat at every table.

Why the usual advice falls short

The usual advice for gaining influence is to build stronger relationships, tell better stories, speak the language of business, and get a seat at the table.

Five problems that get in the way:

Problem	What it means
It's a one-sided goal	Gaining influence is a researcher's goal. Decision makers have their own goals, and being influenced by a researcher isn't usually one of them.

Problem	What it means
Research is a line item	Budgets, timelines, technical limits and business goals all inform a decision. Research is one input among many, not the driver.
Timing is everything	Projects are often planned long before research enters the picture. By then, it's hard to change course.
Research is democratized	Designers, product managers, marketing and HR all do research. There aren't enough researchers to be at every table.
Research is easily forgotten	When a project ends, research goes into team folders, onto laptops, or stays in someone's head, and is rarely shared.

Check your organization's research

Think about the research in your organization, whether you're a researcher or someone who does research without the title. How many of these can you answer with confidence?

- ☐ I know where all existing research across my organization is.
- ☐ I know who and how many people in my organization conduct research.
- ☐ Someone could find existing research without any assistance.
- ☐ I know which research is private and public.
- ☐ All research in my organization follows an established set of rules for how it's conducted and saved.

If you couldn't check all five, there's a good chance what your organization learns from research will be forgotten.

Organizational amnesia

Organizational amnesia is when an organization forgets what it's already learned, because its knowledge has no home, and no system for remembering it. In other words, it has no infrastructure.

The result and the risk: Project teams that repeat research and hear the same complaints from users year after year because root causes and remedies are identified too late or not at all.

The five ResearchOps pillars

Kate Towsey describes ResearchOps as "the systems that enable people to do research, consume research, and act on research." Emma Boulton's [Eight Pillars of User Research](#) map what an organization needs to support research.

These five pillars from my talk work together to cure organizational amnesia.

Pillar	What it does	Questions it answers
Governance	Protects the research	How do we get consent? How do we protect personal information? Who can see which research? How long do we continue to use it?
Data and Knowledge Management	Organizes research so patterns show up	What was learned? When? Who learned it? How sure are we? Have we heard this before?
People and Scope (combined)	Guide how research is done and used	What counts as a finding? Who reviews it? When does a researcher need to step in? How do findings become decisions?
Tools and Infrastructure	Make research findable, shareable, and usable	Where does our research live? Can everyone who needs it get to it? Can rules be built into the tools we want to use? When do we use AI and what should AI never decide on its own?

People and Scope are separate pillars in Boulton's model; here they work together. The other three pillars (Environment, Recruitment and Admin, and Organizational Context) matter too, for other needs.

How it fits together

A research repository gives knowledge a home: one place where all research lives and can be found. The pillars give it a system: rules that sit on top of that repository, so what's in it can be found, understood, and trusted. Together, they create infrastructure, and infrastructure creates influence.

- **The rules are the product.** Agree on how research is captured, connected, trusted, and used, before any tool comes into play.
- **The repository is the container.** Dovetail, SharePoint, a shared drive, or an AI tool your organization already allows all work, as long as your rules can be applied.
- **AI can help but isn't required.** It's great for quickly answering "What do we already know?", but it shouldn't decide on its own what to trust.
- **The rules are an agreement.** Anyone can create the rules, but they work best when created together, by the people who do research and the people who use it.

Where to start, by role

If you are...	Start here
A UX researcher	Map where research lives across teams, including research done by non-researchers. Then propose the first two rules to the people who use research most.

If you are...	Start here
A research or ResearchOps leader	Bring researchers and research users together to agree on what counts as a finding, and when a researcher should step in. Then build those rules into your repository.
A designer, product manager, or anyone doing research without the title	Before your next project, ask "What do we already know?" When you finish, add what you learned where others can find it.
A manager or decision maker	Ask teams to explain what's already known before approving new research, and support a shared place for research to live.

Part 2: Organizational Memory Starter Kit

You don't need a ResearchOps role, a budget, or formal approval to start. This kit walks you through three steps you can begin the week you get back to work, with the templates and AI prompt you need for each. Start small, adapt everything, and build the rules together with the people who use research.

Step 1: Find where your research lives

List every place research and feedback lives in your organization: yours, your team's, and anyone else's who does research. You're looking for where it lives, not judging what it says.

Research inventory

Add one row per place. The first two rows are examples; replace them with your own.

Where it lives	Owner (team)	What kind of research	Sensitive data?	Who can access it	Notes
Shared drive, UX folder	Design	Interviews, usability tests	Participant names in notes	Design team only	Mostly from the last 3 years
Support ticket system	Customer Support	Complaints, feature requests	Yes, customer details	Support team	Ask before using

Places to look

- Research and design folders on shared drives, SharePoint, or Google Drive
- Annual and pulse surveys, including employee surveys
- Support tickets, call recordings, and complaint logs
- Ideas portals and feedback forms
- Team chat channels where feedback gets posted
- Analytics and A/B test results
- Sales and account management notes
- Personal laptops and notebooks (ask people directly)

A "not an audit" message

Some teams may worry you're questioning their work or planning to take it. Send something like this before you ask:

Hi [name],

We're mapping where research and customer feedback live across [organization], so teams can find and reuse what we've already learned.

This isn't an audit. We only want to know where research lives, who owns it, and who can access it. We won't move or share anything without your OK.

Could we have 15 minutes this week to discuss?

Step 2: Write your first rules

Don't try to cover all five pillars at once. Start with two rules, write them in plain language, and treat them as version 1.

Rule 1: What counts as a finding?

A finding is only added to the repository when it answers all five of these:

Question	What to write	Example
What was learned?	One plain sentence	Agents lose notes when a call is transferred.
What's the evidence?	Method and how many people	Interviews with 12 agents; 300 call recordings
When?	Month and year the research was done	March 2026
Who learned it?	Team or person, and who to contact	Contact Center Design team
How sure are we?	High, Medium, or Low, plus one line on why	Medium: one study, but a large sample

Agree on what each confidence level means. A starting point to adapt:

- **High:** seen in two or more studies, and the research is recent enough that nothing important has changed since.
- **Medium:** seen in one solid study, or in older research that hasn't been rechecked.
- **Low:** a small sample, a single source, or anecdotal feedback. Worth checking before acting on it.

Rule 2: When does a researcher need to step in?

Anyone can ask, "What do we already know?" A researcher steps in when judgment is needed. Pick the situations that fit your organization:

- The same problem shows up across three+ studies. It's a pattern, not a feature request.
- Findings conflict with each other.
- The research involves sensitive topics, vulnerable people, or personal data.

- The decision is expensive or hard to reverse.
- No research exists for an important question, or for a whole group of users.
- The research is old enough that it may no longer be true.

Write them together

- Hold one 60-minute session with two or three people who use research to make decisions, such as a product manager, a designer, and someone from legal or privacy.
- Keep the rules where people already look, like your wiki, SharePoint, or the repository itself, not in a new tool nobody opens.
- Create a team, not one person, responsible for keeping the rules up to date. If only one person owns them, the rules can disappear when that person leaves.
- Set a date to review them, three months out.

Step 3: Apply the rules

If you already have a repository, build these into it. If you don't, gather some existing research in one place, such as a shared folder or a tool your organization already allows, and start there.

Findings template

Copy this for every study. It puts Rule 1 into practice.

```
Study: [title]
Goal: [what the study set out to learn]
When: [month and year]
Who ran it: [team, and who to contact]
Method and sample: [e.g. interviews with 12 agents]
Access: [open to everyone / restricted: contact owner]

Finding 1: [what was learned, in one sentence]
Evidence: [what supports it]
How sure we are: [High / Medium / Low] because [one line]
Tags: [from the shared tag list]

Open questions: [what this study didn't answer]
Review by: [date to recheck, e.g. 2 years out]
```

Starter tag list

Most repositories let you add tags, but they don't decide which tags to use or what they mean. If one team writes "login issue" and another writes "sign-in problem," the pattern disappears.

Agree on a short list:

Tag group	Example tags
Who	Customer, Employee, New user, Vendor
Goal	Find information, Complete a task, Get help
Problem type	Can't find it, Too many steps, Confusing wording, Error or bug, Missing feature

Tag group	Example tags
Where	Website, App, Contact center, Internal tool
Journey stage	Discover, Sign up, Use, Get support

Rules for tags:

- One tag per idea. Pick one name and list its synonyms so people can find it ("Sign-in": also login, log in, authentication).
- Use a few specific tags per finding, not many broad ones.
- New tags go through the team that owns the rules.
- Review the list every quarter: merge duplicates and retire tags nobody uses.

Governance checklist

Run this before research goes into the repository or into an AI tool.

- ☐ Participants agreed to this research being stored and reused, not only used for the original study.
- ☐ Names, contact details, and other personal information are removed or hidden.
- ☐ Access is set: open to everyone or restricted with a named owner to contact.
- ☐ A retention date is set, so you know when to review or delete it.
- ☐ The tool you're using is approved for this kind of data.
- ☐ Sensitive research (HR, legal, health) stays restricted, but its title and owner are listed so it isn't repeated.

The AI prompt

Paste this into an AI tool your organization already allows. Replace the three bracketed parts with your rules, your research, and your questions.

Run the governance checklist first: make sure you're allowed to use that research in that tool.

The AI finds what the research says. Your rules decide what you can trust. People make the decisions.

You are helping our organization answer one question before a project starts: "What do we already know?"

Use ONLY the research provided below. Do not use outside knowledge, and do not guess. If the research doesn't answer something, say "Not found in our research."

OUR RULES

[Paste your rules here: what counts as a finding, your confidence levels, your tag list, and when a researcher must step in.]

OUR RESEARCH

[Paste or attach your research here. Each study should include its title, date, who ran it, method and sample, and findings.]

MY QUESTIONS

[Paste your questions here, numbered.]

For each question, answer in this format:

1. Answer: what our research says, in two or three plain sentences.
2. Sources: the studies it comes from, with date and who ran them. Every statement must trace to a study.
3. How sure we are: High, Medium, or Low, using our confidence rules, with one line on why.
4. Where research disagrees: any conflicting findings, or "None found."
5. What we don't know: gaps, including people or groups no study has included.
6. Next step: one of these, with a reason:
 - Use what we know
 - Do a quick check (the research is old or thin)
 - Do new research (nothing exists)
 - Talk to a researcher first (if our rules say a researcher must step in)

Then list:

- Patterns: the same problem showing up across several studies or teams.
- Restricted research: if any study is marked restricted, say only that it exists, its topic, and who to contact. Never share its findings.

Other rules:

- Never include names or personal details about participants.
- Never present a single study as settled fact.
- Recommendations are advice. People make the decisions.

Tip: start with a few well-documented studies. The answers are only as good as the research and the rules you give it.

Keep going

All you need is a place for research to live, a set of rules applied to it, and a desire to turn organizational amnesia into organizational memory.

Want to see the demo I shared during my talk, or discuss how this could work in your organization?

I'd love to hear from you!

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Sources

- Emma Boulton, [The Eight Pillars of User Research](#), ResearchOps Community
- ResearchOps Community, [Revisiting the 8 Pillars of User Research as a foundation for ResearchOps](#)
- Kate Towsey, [Research That Scales: The Research Operations Handbook](#), Rosenfeld Media